Little Lanterns Literacy

Books, stories, and reading time for New Haven's youngest learners

STATUS	501(c)(3) public charity, Connecticut
FOUNDED	2015
BASED IN	Newhallville, New Haven (no office; programs run in libraries and laundromats)
SERVES	Children ages 0–5 and their caregivers in Newhallville and Dixwell
ANNUAL BUDGET	About $68,000
STAFF	1 part-time program lead; otherwise volunteer-run
VOLUNTEERS	About 40 volunteer readers
REACH	About 300 children and 220 caregivers per year; 6,000 books given

MISSION

Little Lanterns lights a love of reading early by putting books in children's hands and giving families joyful, simple ways to read together every day.

OUR STORY

A retired kindergarten teacher started reading aloud at a neighborhood laundromat while families waited for their loads. Kids kept coming back, so she added a free book shelf. Little Lanterns now runs story times in three laundromats and two library branches.

WHO WE SERVE

Families with young children, many raising kids on tight budgets with few books at home. Caregivers include parents, grandparents, and home-based child care providers.

PROGRAMS

Laundromat Story Time
Volunteers read aloud and lead songs at three laundromats on weekends. Every child leaves with a free book to keep.

Lantern Bags
A bag of five books plus a simple tip card on reading together (English and Spanish), given to families at pediatric clinics and community events.

Read Together Circles
A four-week series for caregivers on making reading routines, with child care provided. Runs three or four times a year with 8–12 caregivers each.

HOW WE'RE FUNDED

Individual donors and a book drive (40%), a small community foundation grant (35%), a local credit union sponsorship (15%), and a children's book publisher donation (in-kind).

WHAT WE TRACK TODAY

Books given away (counted by box). Story time headcounts. A one-page sign-in sheet for the Read Together Circles. No follow-up with families after they leave.

WHAT WE'RE WRESTLING WITH

The program lead believes families read more at home, but has no way to show it. A funder suggested measuring kindergarten readiness, which feels far beyond what a volunteer group can track.

A MOMENT FROM OUR WORK

A grandfather who said he 'wasn't a reader' came to a Read Together Circle with his granddaughter. By week four he was doing all the animal voices, and she was correcting him when he skipped a page. (Details changed to protect privacy.)